

THE THREE WILDERNESS ZONES

Every entry in this book is tagged to one or more of the three wilderness zones that define New England's ecological range. Before you go any further, understand what those zones mean on the ground.

▣ **Northern Boreal Zone** *Maine and northern New Hampshire*

This is the far north, ecologically speaking — a landscape more closely related to Canada than to the New England of postcards and leaf-peeping weekends. The dominant trees are red spruce and balsam fir, with black spruce and tamarack in the wetter depressions — black spruce in particular grows in the kind of cold, saturated bogs that feel ancient and slightly hostile, the trees small and twisted and packed close, the ground a sponge of sphagnum moss that swallows a boot to the ankle without ceremony. The canopy is low, dense, and dark. Moose are the apex presence here — you will see their tracks in the mud, their browse on the young firs, their massive bodies moving through the spruce at dawn if you are quiet and fortunate. Canadian lynx still hunt the snowshoe hare in the northernmost reaches of Maine. Black flies hatch in May and make the first weeks of the hiking season a genuine test of character.

The 100-Mile Wilderness — the remote stretch of the Appalachian Trail between Monson, Maine and Baxter State Park — runs through this zone. It is the longest roadless section of the entire AT, and the name is not a metaphor. There are no resupply points, no bailout roads, and no cell service for most of its length. It is magnificent and it is serious.

The boreal zone is where spruce traps live. Dense young spruce regeneration — in areas that were blown down, logged, or burned — can be literally impenetrable. A spruce trap is not a difficult bushwhack. It is a wall. Grown hikers have been found in spruce traps less than a quarter mile from a marked trail, after hours of struggle in a space the size of a tennis court. This is not the terrain to navigate without a map, a compass, and the knowledge to use both.

▮ **Alpine & Subalpine Zone** *White Mountains, Presidential Range, above treeline*

Above 4,500 feet in the White Mountains, the trees end. Not the way they end in a clearcut — gradually, in a battle zone of krummholz (wind-twisted, ground-hugging spruce and fir no taller than your knee) and exposed rock, until suddenly there is nothing above you but sky and weather. This is the alpine zone, and it plays by different rules than any other terrain in New England.

The Presidential Range sits in the direct path of three major storm tracks — the same tracks that hammer the North Atlantic. Weather here does not behave the way it does at the trailhead. A clear morning in the valley can become a whiteout with 60-mph winds and driving horizontal rain in under an hour above treeline. In every month of the year, hypothermia is a realistic danger on the Presidentials. In every month. People have died on Mount Washington in July wearing cotton t-shirts, not because they were reckless but because they did not understand where they were.

The alpine zone is also home to some of the rarest plants in the northeastern United States — arctic-alpine species found nowhere else at this latitude in North America. The *Diapensia*, the Lapland rosebay, the alpine bilberry: these are plants of Greenland and Labrador growing on a New Hampshire mountaintop because the last glacier left conditions cold enough to sustain them. Treat the alpine zone with corresponding care. The growing season above treeline is eight weeks. A boot print in the wrong place can erase a decade of plant growth.

▮ **Mixed Hardwood Corridor** *Green Mountains of Vermont, Berkshires of Massachusetts, Connecticut and Rhode Island highlands, Appalachian Trail corridor*

This is the New England most people picture: the explosion of orange and red in October, the stone walls running through second-growth forest, the sugar maple stands, the ridge-top views south toward civilization. It is beautiful and it is wild — genuinely wild, with black bear, coyote, fisher, bobcat, and timber rattlesnake all present in varying numbers depending on where in the corridor you are.

The Mixed Hardwood zone is also the most ecologically diverse zone in the book. Sugar maple, yellow birch, American beech, red oak, and eastern hemlock dominate the canopy. The understory is rich — wild ramps, trout lily, fiddlehead fern, and trillium in spring; elderberry, wild blueberry, and black raspberry in summer; hen of the woods mushrooms at the base of the oaks in fall. This is where foraging is most rewarding and where the look-alike risks are most real, because the diversity of species means that the deadly ones grow alongside the edible ones, sometimes within arm's reach of each other.



The AT corridor runs through this zone for most of its New England mileage, passing through the Berkshires of Massachusetts, the Green Mountains of Vermont, and the lower White Mountains of New Hampshire before entering the boreal zone north of Crawford Notch.